

THE AVERAGERS



RAVI S SAHANI

C.P. JOSHI

• Rural Development Minister

• **AGENDA** One of the priorities of the Government was to enlarge the scope of works under the National Rural Employment Guarantee Act, presently limited to unskilled manual work. Other plans included ensuring transparency, independent monitoring and grievance redressal mechanisms.

• **PERFORMANCE** Joshi has kept his promise. The Government amended Schedule I of NREGA in July to allow works to include "provision of irrigation facility, horticulture plantation, and land development facilities to land owned by households belonging to the Scheduled Castes and Scheduled Tribes or below poverty line families".



SIPRA DAS

A. RAJA

• Telecom Minister

• **AGENDA** 3G for telecom, 20p for STD calls, e-G in IT and corporatisation of India Post were the mantras Raja chanted soon after he vanquished rumours of his ouster and rivalries within his party to be sworn as the Telecom Minister.

• **PERFORMANCE** Raja has managed to get the reserve price for 3G auctions (and WiMax) cleared but is stuck on critical issues like clogged spectrum and customer benefits. For instance, existing and new players will have to wait till January 2010 for clearance of 2G spectrum and it's been a long wait for consumers for number portability. The sector is still the fastest growing with 15 million new connections a month and more competition will deliver lower cost. What Raja still can't shake off though are the waves of controversy that clog the spectrum.



REUBEN SINGH

KAMAL NATH

• Transport Minister

• **AGENDA** One of the infrastructure ministries that has come out with ambitious announcements to turn around the National Highways Development Programme. Nath had set a target of adding 20 km a day, 7,000 km a year and 35,000 km by 2014. The ministry fixed a 10-times jump in building highways from the present target of 2 km per day.

• **PERFORMANCE** Though Nath has started firefighting, the Government is struggling to find bidders who will take up the construction of roads due to the recession. Still, Nath has taken up the issue of procedural delays and there are hopes that, even if not ten-fold, road construction will see an increase from the sluggish past.